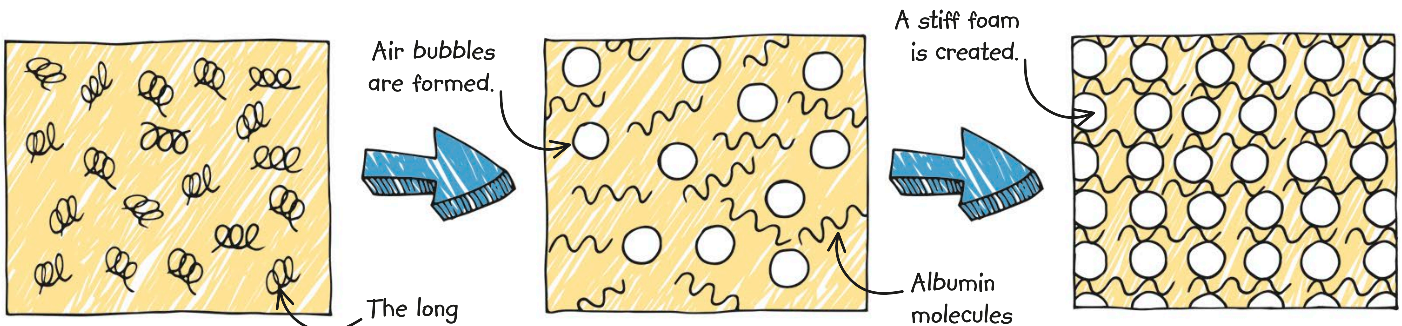
HOW IT WORKS

Egg white is mostly water, with a little sugar dissolved in it, plus long molecules of protein (mostly one called albumin). In their natural state, albumin molecules are coiled up. But when you whisk egg whites, the molecules uncoil. These then join together, trapping tiny pockets of air in between them. Air is a good heat insulator, which means that heat passes through it very slowly. So, while the surface of your Baked Alaska cooks quickly, the heat takes much longer to pass right through the trapped air to the ice cream.

This dessert is named after the American state of Alaska, where it gets very cold.



Egg white is 90 percent water and 10 percent protein. It's the proteins that make egg white gloopy.

Beating egg whites unwinds the albumin molecules and introduces millions of tiny air bubbles.

The albumin molecules join up, trapping the air bubbles. When the foam is cooked, it hardens and browns—it's a meringue!

REAL WORLD SCIENCE
INCREDIBLE IGLOOS

Like beaten egg whites, snow contains lots of trapped air, and is a very good insulator. That's why people can stay warm in an igloo, a shelter made from bricks of snow and traditionally built by communities living in northern Canada, Alaska, and Greenland.

KEEPING WARM

Body heat warms the air inside an igloo, and the snow slows down heat loss. Igloos, now used mostly by explorers and mountaineers, can save lives in snowstorms.